

AFRO CUBAN 12/8

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #155

The Afro Cuban feel generally points us to a 12/8 groove, with a tempo usually around mm = +/- 120. There. Now you know more than most jazz musicians! This is one of the typical four or five styles that we find ourselves in as a jazz player, and this style has an extremely deep history, going back to West Africa.

This 12/8 (Bembé) feel is also very deep rhythmically. There are a multitude of variations on the basic bell pattern (the rhythm), and endless subdivisions and rhythmic repercussions due to the many subdivisions available thanks to the 12/8 time signature. In short, this sheet is a great start, and barely scratching the surface!

#1 - 12/8 Bell Pattern (Bembé)



This is one of the basic bell patterns for Afro Cuban 12/8, often called Bembé.

#2 - The same pattern (more or less) in 4/4



Here it is, translated (not quite exactly) into 4/4, which might be easier to look at.

#3 - Downbeat based rhythm



#4 - Downbeat rhythm w. scale



#5 - Upbeat based rhythm



#6 - Upbeat rhythm w. scale

